



Oh shoot here we go again*

Adèle Hénót-Mortier (QMUL)



Data and Puzzle

Key data.

(1) *Jo and Al are introduced to each other at a party and spontaneously share their names. As the conversation goes by, Jo realizes they forgot Al's name. Jo asks Al:*

- What's your name **again**? English
- C'est quoi ton nom **déjà**? French

Both (1a) & (1b) suggest Al's age was Common Ground (**CG**) before (Sauerland and Yatsushiro 2017, now **SY17**¹). SY17 dubbed it "Remind-me" presupposition (**RMP**) and showed the repetitive presupposition of *again* can produce it via interactions with Speech Act operators.²

- $\llbracket (1a) \rrbracket = \text{IMP}_2 (\text{again } (\text{CG}(Q)))$
= Make CG again the answer to 'what's your age?'.
 $\leadsto$ Age was CG **before**.

Puzzle. *Déjà* does not mean *again*! It means *ever*, *before*, *already* (Lecavelier & Wimmer, 2025a, 2025c), or *first off*.

- Jo a **déjà** mangé des escargots (?)
Jo has **before/ever** eaten some snails (?)
 - Tu as **déjà** fini de manger (?)
You have **already** finished to eat (?)
 - Je vais **déjà/d'abord** retirer mes chaussures.
I will **first** take-off my shoes.

None of these uses carry the desired presupposition; though (3a) (*before/ever* reading) asserts something close.

Upshot. The *ever*-reading of *déjà* interacts with 2 CG operators to effectively **background the assertion that *déjà*'s prejacent occurred before**—thereby producing the RMP.

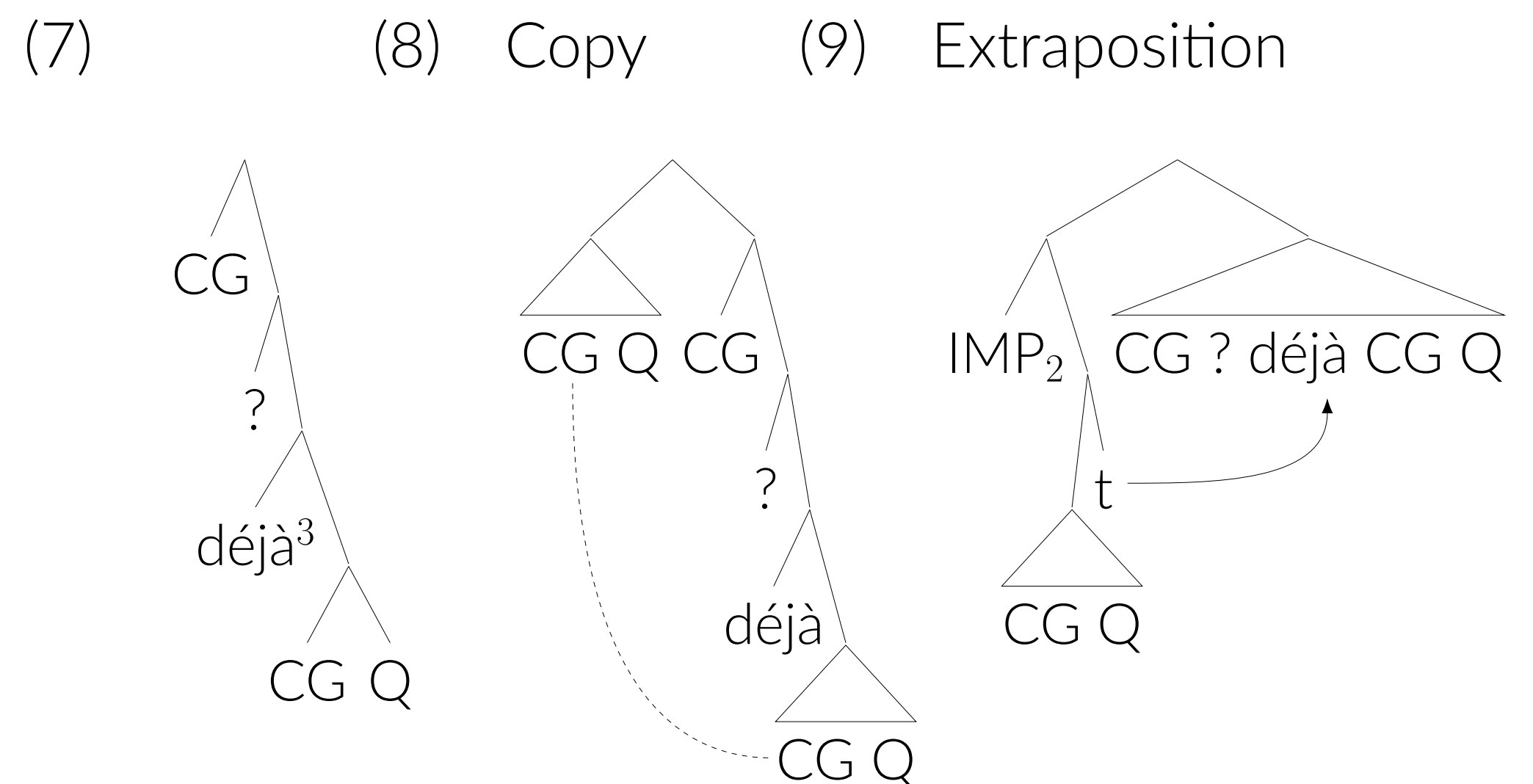
Key assumptions

- $\llbracket \text{CG} \rrbracket^{\text{spk}} = \lambda \langle Q, e \rangle. 1$ iff spk partakes in e ,
and Q 's full answer is CG in e
- $\llbracket \text{IMP}_2 \rrbracket^{\text{spk, addr}} = \lambda p. \Box \exists e. \text{addr causes } e \text{ and } p(e)$
- $\llbracket \text{déjà} \rrbracket = \lambda \langle p, e \rangle. \exists e' < e. p(e') = 1$

¹See also Sauerland (2006), Pittner (2009), Sauerland (2009), Dayal (2025), and Lecavelier and Wimmer (2025a, 2025b, 2025c).

²This extends to specialized particles like Japanese *-kake* (SY17).

The account at a glance



- $\llbracket (7) \rrbracket = \text{It's CG that } Q\text{'s answer was CG before (=RMP)}$
- $\llbracket (9) \rrbracket = \text{Make CG the answer to } Q \text{ (=core question), and it's CG that } Q\text{'s answer was CG before (=RMP)}.$

The placement of *déjà* (pre/post-sentential) is decided by which copy of Q gets realized at PF.

Extensions and further questions

Polar questions. Unlike German *noch mal*, RMP-*déjà* moves past CG overtly, so there's no apriori reason to not get RMPs in polar questions. Yet, RMPs only arise in alternative polar questions...I'm not sure why!

- Tu viens ??(ou pas) déjà?

"First off" déjà. The "first off" reading of *déjà*, which presupposes that the prejacent is the first element of a longer to-do list, may also be recycled at the Speech Act level.

- Al and Jo meet for the first time at a party, and Al quickly starts raving about GLOW48. Al interrupts them:*

Déjà c'est quoi ton nom? ('What's your name first?')

$\leadsto$ I will ask you other questions (*déjà* > IMP_2)

$\leadsto$ Other facts will be made CG (IMP_2 > *déjà* > CG)

Why not use *again* in French? Maybe the fact that *déjà* is so polyvalent outweighs the difficulty of the derivation.

Other triggers. Beyond *again* and *already/ever*, Lecavelier and Wimmer (2025b) observe that *now* and the past tense can trigger the RMP. Why is that?

*Many thanks to Jeanne Lecavelier and Alexander Wimmer for sharing their insights with me on that topic. Thanks also to the reviewers of NELS56, TaLK2026, GLOW48 and SALT36. Special thanks to the audience of TaLK2026, esp. Veneeta Dayal, Tim Jantarungsee, Arum Kang, Junri Shimada, Frank Sode and Joseph Tabolt.

³In practice RMP-*déjà* originates in VP and moves up here overtly.

References

- Beck, S. (1996). Quantified structures as barriers for If movement. *Natural Language Semantics*, 4(1), 1–56. <https://doi.org/10.1007/bf00263536>
- Beck, S. (2006). Intervention effects follow from focus interpretation*. *Natural Language Semantics*, 14(1), 1–56. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11050-005-4532-y>
- Bošković, Ž. (2000). Sometimes in speccp, sometimes in-situ. *Step by Step: Essays on Minimalist Syntax in Honor of Howard Lasnik*.
- Chang, L. (1997). Wh-in-situ phenomena in french [Doctoral dissertation, University of British Columbia].
- Dayal, V. (2025). The interrogative left periphery: How a clause becomes a question. *Linguistic Inquiry*, 56(4), 663–712. https://doi.org/10.1162/ling_a_00507
- Ippolito, M. (2024). The hell with questions. *Journal of Semantics*, 41(1), 53–76. <https://doi.org/10.1093/jos/ffae001>
- Lecavelier, J., & Wimmer, A. (2025a). Forgetting and the common ground [Unpublished manuscript].
- Lecavelier, J., & Wimmer, A. (2025b). How do remind-me questions work again?
- Lecavelier, J., & Wimmer, A. (2025c). What is the function of French déjà in questions again?
- Obenauer, H.-G. (1994). Aspects de la syntaxe a-barre : Effets d'intervention et mouvements des quantificateurs [Doctoral dissertation, Paris 8].
- Pesetsky, D. (2000). *Phrasal movement and its kin*. MIT Press.
- Pittner, K. (2009). Wieder als modalpartikel. *Zeitschrift für germanistische Linguistik*, 37, 296–314.
- Sauerland, U. (2006). Decomposing questions acts. In H.-M. Gärtner, S. Beck, R. Eckardt, R. Musan, & B. Stiebels (Eds.), *Between 40 and 60 puzzles for krifka*. Zentrum für Allgemeine Sprachwissenschaft. <http://www.zas.gwz-berlin.de/fileadmin/material/40-60-puzzles-for-krifka/>
- Sauerland, U. (2009). Decomposing questions acts. *Snippets*, (20), 62–63.
- Sauerland, U., & Yatsushiro, K. (2017). Remind-me presuppositions and speech-act decomposition: Evidence from particles in questions. *Linguistic Inquiry*, 48(4), 651–678. https://doi.org/10.1162/ling_a_00257
- Yatsushiro, K. (1999). *Case licensing and vp structure* [Doctoral dissertation, University of Connecticut].

Link to extra materials: https://adelemortier.github.io/files/TaLK_2026_slides.pdf